

Rationalism — MCQ Questions

40-question closed-book bank · no answer key

Attempt closed-book. Record option, reasoning and confidence in PRACTICE-LOG.md before opening MCQ-SOLUTIONS.md. Questions retain canonical numbering; no key or explanation is present here.

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MCQ 1. What the rationalist thesis actually asserts

Consider the following statements about early-modern rationalism.

1. It denies that sense-experience can by itself supply the warrant for necessity and universality.
2. It holds that the structure of reality is accessible to reason, and explains that structure through substance, attribute and mode.
3. It maintains that sensory beliefs are uniformly false and that the physical world is an illusion.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 3 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 2 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

MCQ 2. Which rule of method does the destructive work

In the *Discourse on the Method*, Part II, Descartes states four rules. The rule that generates the wholesale demolition of Meditation I is the rule requiring him to

- A. divide every difficulty under examination into as many parts as its solution requires
- B. conduct his thoughts in order, beginning with the simplest and easiest objects
- C. accept nothing as true which he does not clearly and evidently know to be so
- D. make his enumerations so complete and his reviews so general that nothing is omitted

MCQ 3. The order of the three doubts

Match each stage of Cartesian doubt with what it is designed to remove.

1. Sense-deception — 2. The dream argument — 3. The evil genius (*genius malignus*)

I. Even the simple truths of arithmetic and geometry. II. The reliability of particular perceptual judgements about how things appear. III. The immediate perceptual situation, and with it the whole external world.

Which of the following is the correct matching?

- A. 1–II, 2–III, 3–I
- B. 1–III, 2–I, 3–II
- C. 1–I, 2–II, 3–III

D. 1–II, 2–I, 3–III

MCQ 4. The logical status of "I am, I exist"

Descartes' claim that he exists whenever he thinks is best characterised as

- A. an inductive generalisation drawn from many observed instances of his own thinking activity
- B. a deduction from the suppressed major premise that whatever thinks must exist
- C. an empirical report of an inner sensation whose occurrence he happens to notice
- D. an immediate intuition whose certainty is performative and confined to the present moment

MCQ 5. The limits of what the thinking self establishes

Consider the following statements about what the *cogito* by itself establishes.

1. That thinking is occurring, and that the thinker exists while thinking.
2. That the thinker is an enduring immaterial substance numerically identical over time.
3. That there is at least one proposition immune to the hypothesis of a powerful deceiver.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 1 and 3 only
- C. 2 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

MCQ 6. Sorting the three kinds of ideas

Match each class of idea with its correct description.

1. Adventitious (*adventitiae*) — 2. Factitious (*factitiae*) — 3. Innate (*innatae*)

I. Native to the mind's own rational nature and elicited on an appropriate occasion. II. Received as though from outside, arriving involuntarily through a passive faculty. III. Constructed voluntarily by the mind out of ideas it already possesses.

Which of the following is the correct matching?

- A. 1–II, 2–III, 3–I
- B. 1–I, 2–II, 3–III
- C. 1–III, 2–I, 3–II

MCQ 7. What Descartes means by an innate idea

The strongest formulation of Cartesian innateness — the one that Locke's appeal to the absence of universal assent does not reach — is that an innate idea is

- A. a proposition consciously affirmed by every human being from the earliest moment of life
- B. a sensory impression so frequently repeated that it has become impossible to doubt
- C. an image stored in the memory before birth and later recovered by a distinct act of recollection
- D. a native disposition of the intellect which produces the idea on an appropriate occasion

MCQ 8. Locke's grounds of refutation

Consider the following as grounds on which Locke rejects innate principles in the *Essay concerning Human Understanding*, Book I.

1. Alleged innate principles command no universal assent, since children and others do not affirm them.
2. Nothing can be said to be in the mind and yet unknown to it, on pain of making every knowable truth innate.
3. The idea of infinity is demonstrably richer than anything the mind could ever construct from finite materials.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 3 only
- B. 1 and 2 only
- C. 2 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

MCQ 9. What the wax argument establishes

The conclusion the wax argument of Meditation II is designed to secure is that

- A. the wax has no real properties at all once its sensible qualities have been destroyed by heat
- B. bodily identity through qualitative change is grasped by the intellect rather than by sense
- C. the senses are wholly inoperative and contribute nothing whatever to any human judgement
- D. the existence of external material bodies follows directly from the persistence of the wax

MCQ 10. Why imagination cannot do the work

In the wax argument, the reason Descartes rejects imagination as the faculty by which the wax is grasped is that

- A. imagination is always accompanied by a sensory impression and so inherits every sensory defect
- B. imagination belongs to the body and is therefore extinguished whenever the body is altered
- C. heat can give the wax indefinitely many shapes, which no finite run of images could ever exhaust
- D. imagination operates only on objects that are absent, whereas the wax is present to him

MCQ 11. Matching the proofs of God to their strategy

Match each Cartesian proof of God with its distinctive argumentative move.

1. Trademark or causal — 2. Conservation — 3. Ontological

I. Existence is contained in the concept of a supremely perfect being, so its denial is a contradiction. II. I cannot sustain my own existence from one moment to the next, so a continuing cause is required. III. The content of my idea of an infinite being exceeds anything a finite mind could have produced.

Which of the following is the correct matching?

- A. 1–III, 2–II, 3–I
- B. 1–I, 2–III, 3–II
- C. 1–II, 2–I, 3–III
- D. 1–III, 2–I, 3–II

MCQ 12. The Cartesian Circle and the reply

Arnauld's objection in the Fourth Objections, and Descartes' reply to it, are best stated as follows:

- A. the objection is that God cannot be proved at all, and the reply is that the idea of God is innate rather than voluntarily made
- B. the objection is that the *cogito* is really a syllogism, and the reply is that it is an immediate intuition
- C. the objection is that the senses cannot ever be trusted, and the reply is that a perfect God would never deceive
- D. the objection is that the criterion proves God who certifies it, and the reply separates attended from remembered perception

MCQ 13. The proof of the external world

Consider the following steps in Descartes' Meditation VI argument for material things.

1. Sensory ideas arrive involuntarily, so I possess a passive faculty of receiving them.
2. I have a great natural inclination to refer these ideas to bodies, and no faculty by which the inclination could be corrected.
3. The wax argument has already demonstrated that at least one extended body exists outside me.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 3 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 2 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

MCQ 14. The argument for the real distinction

The reasoning by which Descartes concludes that mind and body are really distinct proceeds by holding that

- A. whatever can be clearly and distinctly conceived apart can by God's power exist apart, and so is distinct
- B. whatever is observed to behave independently in the course of ordinary experience must be a separate substance
- C. whatever has a different location in the body must belong to a different kind of created thing
- D. whatever survives the hypothesis of the evil genius is thereby shown to be immaterial in nature

MCQ 15. The interaction problem and the pineal gland

Descartes' appeal to the pineal gland, and Princess Elisabeth's objection to his position, are best understood as follows:

- A. the gland is the seat of the soul, a claim Elisabeth accepts while denying that any such soul can be immortal
- B. the gland gives interaction a location, while Elisabeth asks how the unextended could move the extended
- C. the gland is the organ of imagination, which Elisabeth argues should instead be assigned to the intellect
- D. the gland dissolves the problem entirely, and Elisabeth's objection concerns only the physiology of the nerves

MCQ 16. Error and the grades of freedom in Meditation IV

According to Descartes' account of error and freedom, error arises because the will is

- A. finite while the intellect is infinite, so that understanding constantly outruns what may be affirmed
- B. determined by bodily motions, so that assent is compelled by mechanical causes outside the mind
- C. most free when it is wholly indifferent, since indifference alone leaves alternatives genuinely open
- D. infinite in scope while the intellect is finite, so that assent may be given beyond clear perception

MCQ 17. Spinoza's argument for one substance

The demonstration by which Spinoza reaches a single substance turns essentially on the premise that

- A. two substances cannot share an attribute, so nothing whatever could distinguish them as substances
- B. God is defined at the outset as the only being whose essence involves its own existence
- C. extension is divisible and therefore cannot belong to what is ultimately real in nature
- D. thought and extension are known to us, while infinitely many further attributes remain unknown

MCQ 18. Attributes, modes and the contrast with Descartes

For Spinoza, thought and extension are best described as

- A. two finite modes which together exhaust the content of the one infinite substance
- B. two created substances which depend for their existence on the infinite substance
- C. two attributes, each expressing the whole eternal essence of the one substance
- D. two aspects of human perception which do not correspond to anything in substance

MCQ 19. "Whatever is, is in God"

In *Ethics* I, P15 and P18 together, the claim that whatever is, is in God, is best understood as asserting that

- A. finite things are spatially contained within a divine body that extends throughout the whole universe
- B. finite things exist as modes of the one substance, whose immanent and not transitive cause is God
- C. finite things were produced by an act of will at a moment in time and are conserved by divine choice
- D. finite things are appearances with no reality of their own, since only the infinite is genuinely real

MCQ 20. Pantheism, panentheism and acosmism

Consider the following statements about the standard labels applied to Spinoza's God.

1. Pantheism, in the qualified sense that nothing exists outside God and all things are modes within the one immanent substance.
2. Acosmism, the charge associated with Hegel that if only substance is real then the finite world dissolves into nothing.
3. Panentheism, the reading on which all things are in God while God exceeds the finite modes and the two attributes we know.

Which of the statements given above correctly describe positions taken in the interpretive debate?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

MCQ 21. Necessity in *Ethics* I

Consider the following statements about Spinoza's necessitarianism.

1. P16 holds that infinitely many things in infinitely many ways follow from the necessity of the divine nature.
2. P29 holds that nothing in nature is contingent, apparent contingency recording only ignorance of causes.
3. The derivation is ontological rather than temporal, so it is not a story in which God first exists and later produces a world.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

MCQ 22. Parallelism as a solution to the mind–body problem

Spinoza's doctrine that the order and connection of ideas is the same as the order and connection of things has the consequence that

- A. a mental event and a bodily event are one and the same single mode expressed under two attributes

- B. mental events cause bodily events, but only through the mediation of the infinite intellect
- C. bodily events cause mental events, since the mind is the idea of an already existing body
- D. mental and bodily events belong to two substances whose sequences God continually adjusts

MCQ 23. The three kinds of knowledge and the fourth proportional

In Spinoza's example of finding the fourth proportional to 1, 2 and 3, the merchant who applies a remembered rule, the mathematician who demonstrates it from the common property of proportionals, and the person who sees at once that the answer is 6, exemplify respectively

- A. reason, imagination and intuitive knowledge, in that order of increasing adequacy
- B. imagination, intuitive knowledge and reason, since demonstration is the highest form
- C. imagination, reason and intuitive knowledge, in that order of increasing adequacy
- D. intuitive knowledge, reason and imagination, since immediacy is the least reliable

MCQ 24. Definition 7 and the meaning of Spinozist freedom

Ethics I, Definition 7 states that a thing is free which exists solely from the necessity of its own nature and is determined to action by itself alone. This definition contrasts freedom with

- A. causation as such, so that a free act must be an event without any determining cause whatever
- B. external compulsion, so that a thing is free as far as it acts from its own understood nature
- C. rational deliberation, so that freedom belongs to spontaneous impulse rather than to understanding
- D. divine necessity, so that human freedom consists in an exemption from the general order of nature

MCQ 25 (remedial). The provenance of "all determination is negation"

Which of the following statements about the formula *omnis determinatio est negatio* is correct?

- A. It is a proposition of *Ethics I*, demonstrated immediately after the definition of substance itself
- B. It is a phrase of Descartes, later applied to Spinoza by nineteenth-century commentators
- C. It universalises a remark in Spinoza's Letter 50 and entered the textbooks through Hegel
- D. It is a formulation of Leibniz, used to explain why no two monads can be exactly alike

MCQ 26 (remedial). Perception is not consciousness

Which of the following correctly states Leibniz's position on the mental life of monads?

- A. Every monad has perception, but only some have the reflexive awareness called apperception
- B. Every monad has apperception, since a perception without any awareness would be a contradiction
- C. Only rational spirits have perception, while lower monads possess appetition alone
- D. Only God has perception, and created monads merely reflect it without possessing it

MCQ 27 (remedial). Individuality and the status of bodies

Consider the following statements about Leibniz's account of individuality and of extended bodies.

1. No two monads are exactly alike, since God would have no sufficient reason to create indistinguishable duplicates.
2. An organism is coordinated by a dominant monad together with an aggregate of subordinate monads.
3. Extended bodies are well-founded phenomena, grounded in ordered monadic aggregates rather than being arbitrary illusions.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

MCQ 28 (remedial). Harmony, influence and assistance

Leibniz distinguishes his own solution to the mind–body question from two rivals. His position is that the correspondence between mental and bodily series is secured by

- A. a continuous divine adjustment of both series at every moment, as occasionalism maintains
- B. a single arrangement made at creation, so that each series unfolds internally and they agree
- C. a direct causal link between the two series, located in a central and unpaired organ of the brain
- D. an identity between the two series, since they are one and the same thing described in two ways

MCQ 29 (remedial). Two kinds of truth and two kinds of necessity

Which of the following correctly distinguishes Leibniz's two kinds of truth and the modal claim he derives from them?

- A. Truths of reason are contingent and analysable only infinitely, whereas truths of fact are necessary and can be analysed finitely
- B. Both kinds are necessary, and the only difference lies in whether human beings are able to complete the analysis
- C. Truths of reason are necessary with finite analysis; truths of fact are contingent, and their necessity is only hypothetical
- D. Both kinds are contingent, since God could have chosen a world in which the truths of mathematics were different

MCQ 30 (remedial). What Leibnizian freedom requires

Leibniz's account of human freedom requires which of the following conditions to hold together?

- A. Indifference of the will, absence of divine foreknowledge, and the reality of chance in nature
- B. Spontaneity alone, since any action arising from the agent's own inner nature is by that very fact free
- C. Intelligence and contingency alone, spontaneity being ruled out by the windowlessness of monads
- D. Spontaneity, intelligence and contingency, with reasons inclining the will without necessitating it

MCQ 31 (remedial). Attribution and provenance in answer-writing

Which of the following attributions is correct?

- A. "The ghost in the machine" is Gilbert Ryle's hostile description of Cartesian dualism, coined in 1949
- B. "The ghost in the machine" is Descartes' own summary of the union of mind and body
- C. "The best of all possible worlds" is Voltaire's doctrine, which Leibniz satirised in his *Theodicy*
- D. "The order and connection of ideas is the same as the order and connection of things" is from the *Monadology*

MCQ 32 (remedial). What a comparative answer must contain

In answering a question that asks whose account of the mind–body problem is compatible with human freedom, the feature that most distinguishes a high-scoring script is that it

- A. narrates all three systems in sequence, giving each an equal number of lines and no conclusion

- B. announces the criterion of freedom being used, ranks all three against it, and defends the ranking
- C. selects one philosopher at the outset and expounds him at length without discussing the others
- D. lists the standard criticisms of each position and leaves the reader to adjudicate between the three

MCQ 33. The Circle after the memory reply

Consider the following statements about Descartes' reply to the Cartesian Circle.

1. A clear and distinct perception presently attended to is claimed to compel assent without first borrowing God's guarantee.
2. Divine veracity is assigned the work of securing remembered perceptions and extended demonstrations whose earlier steps are no longer before the mind.
3. The reply remains vulnerable because the proofs of God are themselves extended arguments whose earlier premises must be remembered.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 1, 2 and 3
- C. 2 and 3 only
- D. 1 and 3 only

MCQ 34. Dispositional innateness under Locke's attack

A critic observes that infants and people lacking the relevant concepts do not assent to alleged innate principles. Which assessment best follows?

- A. The observation refutes every form of innateness because a native cognitive capacity must always occur as a consciously affirmed proposition.
- B. The observation is irrelevant even to occurrent innatism because universal assent is not evidence for or against mental content.
- C. The observation proves that mathematical necessity is copied from sensation and that no rational disposition is needed to grasp it.
- D. It directly pressures occurrent innatism, but dispositional innatism survives unless the critic also shows that no specific native capacity is required.

MCQ 35. From conatus to freedom without escaping necessity

A person first reacts to an insult through a passive affect, then forms an adequate understanding of its causes and acts from that understanding. On Spinoza's account, this transition is best described as

- A. the person's *conatus* becoming more active through adequate causation, so freedom increases only as self-determination within the necessary order.
- B. a suspension of the causal order by a rational will, so the later action could occur without any sufficient determining cause.
- C. the replacement of bodily determination by an independent mental substance capable of initiating a new causal chain outside the bodily order.
- D. an escape from divine necessity made possible by intuitive knowledge, while ordinary rational knowledge remains passive and externally determined.

MCQ 36. Complete concepts and cross-world contingency

Consider the following claims about Leibniz's proposition that Caesar crossed the Rubicon.

1. The predicate belongs to Caesar's complete individual concept and is certain in the actual world.
2. Its negation is nevertheless logically conceivable through a different possible individual in another compossible world.
3. God's selection of this world makes the event hypothetically rather than absolutely necessary.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1, 2 and 3
- D. 1 and 3 only

MCQ 37. Assistance, harmony and the cost of intervention

Which assessment most accurately distinguishes occasionalism from Leibniz's pre-established harmony?

- A. Occasionalism permits direct causal traffic between created substances, whereas harmony requires God to recreate both series at each instant.
- B. Occasionalism and harmony are identical because both deny created interaction and therefore assign every finite event the same immediate cause.
- C. Harmony coordinates mind and body by treating them as two attributes of one substance, while occasionalism preserves two substances through initial synchronisation.
- D. Occasionalism invokes continuing divine assistance, whereas harmony is set at creation; Leibniz argues that repeated adjustment resembles a defective craftsman's continuous repair.

MCQ 38. Parallelism without two coordinated substances

A decision to raise one's arm and the corresponding bodily sequence are considered under Spinoza's attributes of Thought and Extension. Which description is correct?

- A. They are events in two created substances whose agreement is maintained by God's continuous intervention whenever either series changes.
- B. They are one modal order expressed under two attributes, with no causal traffic from mind to body or body to mind.
- C. They are independent monadic series synchronised at creation, each unfolding internally despite having no common underlying substance.
- D. They are two interacting modes joined at the pineal gland, although their distinct essences remain thought and extension throughout the causal sequence.

MCQ 39. The architecture of the external-world proof

Which sequence correctly reconstructs Descartes' proof of material things in *Meditation VI*?

- A. Vivid sensory content proves resemblance to external bodies; those bodies establish God, who then confirms every perceived sensible quality.
- B. The wax proves body's existence and extension; involuntary sensations then exclude both the self and God as their active cause.
- C. Involuntary ideas require an active cause; natural inclination refers them to bodies; without a corrective faculty, divine non-deception supports extended things.
- D. Clear and distinct perception directly reveals bodies; the dream argument removes sensible qualities; the *cogito* supplies their external cause.

MCQ 40. Why the first method rule demolishes classes

Consider the following statements about the first Cartesian rule of method.

1. It withholds assent from whatever is not clearly evident rather than merely lowering confidence in doubtful propositions.
2. A counterexample to a source's reliability can deprive an entire class of beliefs of the required evident status, producing cumulative class-wide suspension.
3. The demolition is methodological rather than terminal: it seeks a foundation from which knowledge can be reconstructed.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1, 2 and 3
- B. 1 and 2 only

C. 2 and 3 only

D. 1 and 3 only